

Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

♠ A 7 2
 ♥ Q J 10 8
 ♦ 9 5
 ♣ K J 9 3

♠ K Q 3

♥ 9 6 4

♦ A Q 7 3

♣ 6 4 2



♠ J 10 9 5
 ♥ 7 5 2
 ♦ 8 6 4
 ♣ Q 10 5

♠ 8 6 4

♥ A K 3

♦ K J 10 2

♣ A 8 7

West	North	East	South
Pass	3NT		1NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♥Q

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=4 ♣=1 Total = 7

Needing two more winners you will have to make both the ♠K and ♠Q. This will only be possible if West holds the ♠A. Win the first trick (if you don't West might switch to ♣s) and play a small ♠ toward dummy's ♠Q. It holds the trick.

You should take your four ♦ winners now, being sure to end up in your hand. Then play another small ♠ toward dummy's ♠K. This also wins.

You have now won 7 tricks so don't mess around now. Take your two Aces and let them have the last four tricks.

If East held the ♠A you would not have made the contract.

A Simple Finesse has only a 50% success rate. That's why we only take finesses as a last resort.

Board 2

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 4 3
♥ 9 8 2
♦ K J 6 3
♣ J 9 7

♠ 9 8 6

♥ A K Q J 4

♦ A 7 4

♣ A 2

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♠ K J 5 2

♥ 7 5 3

♦ Q 10

♣ K Q 10 5

♠ A Q 7

♥ 10 6

♦ 9 8 5 2

♣ 8 6 4 3

West

North

East

South

1♥

Pass

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♦ 3

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♦ 3.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=5 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 8

You need just one more winner. Since West probably has 4 ♦s you will not be able to establish a trick in that suit, so your only hope is the ♠Q. You win the first ♦ so they don't get a chance to switch to ♣s, a suit you are worse off in. Then take your 5 ♥ tricks, ending in dummy.

You can't put it off any longer so play a small ♠ from dummy and put the ♠Q on. If it wins you will make your contract, if it loses you won't.

East held the ♠K so you were lucky this time.

But remember, finesses only work half the time. The other half they lose.

Board 3

North Deals

None Vul

♠ A 10 7
 ♥ Q J 10 9
 ♦ J 7 4
 ♣ 10 6 3

♠ 6 5 3

♥ 8 6 4 2

♦ K 6

♣ K J 5 2



♠ Q J 9 4

♥ 7 5 3

♦ Q 10 9 2

♣ 9 4

♠ K 8 2

♥ A K

♦ A 8 5 3

♣ A Q 8 7

West	North	East	South
	Pass	Pass	2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♥Q			

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=2 ♣=4 Total = 8

Needing one more winner you should see right away that it cannot come from ♥s, ♦s, or ♣s. That means you must hope that East has the ♠A. Win the first ♥, then play your 4 ♣ winners ending in dummy.

The moment of truth. You lead a small ♠ from dummy. East plays low and you play the ♠K.

Unfortunately West takes your ♠K with the ♠A. He then plays another ♥ and you at least make 8 tricks but have no hope for a ninth one so you go down 1.

You probably thought since these Deals were all about finesses that they would work all of the time.

Welcome to the real world.

Board 4

South Deals

None Vul

♠ K Q 9 3

♥ 10

♦ K 10 6 5

♣ 10 7 3 2

♠ 8 6 2

♥ 8 4 3 2

♦ A Q 7 4

♣ 9 5



♠ J 10 5

♥ A 6

♦ J 9 3 2

♣ A 8 6 4

♠ A 7 4

♥ K Q J 9 7 5

♦ 8

♣ K Q J

West	North	East	South
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Pass

2♥

Pass

1♥

4♥

All Pass

4♥ by South

Lead: ♠K

hand. So you start pulling trumps and establishing the ♣s.

If the ♦ finesse had lost you would have gone down 2 instead of just one.

The risk was worthwhile though since it gave you your only chance of making the contract.

South is to play 4♥. West leads the ♠K.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=1 Total = 4

West found the best opening lead for his side, exposing your ♠ losers before you could establish the ♣ suit for a discard. If you start to pull trumps right away the defense will grab the ♥A, then take their two ♠ tricks and you will still have the ♣A that you cannot avoid.

Other than the ♦A the only useful card in dummy is the ♦Q so you must try to make a winner out of that for a discard. So win the ♠A, lead your singleton ♦ and finesse the ♦Q. Your luck has returned, the ♦Q wins and you discard one of your ♠ losers on the ♦A.

At this point you have not lost any tricks, and you can see that you have only 3 losers remaining in your